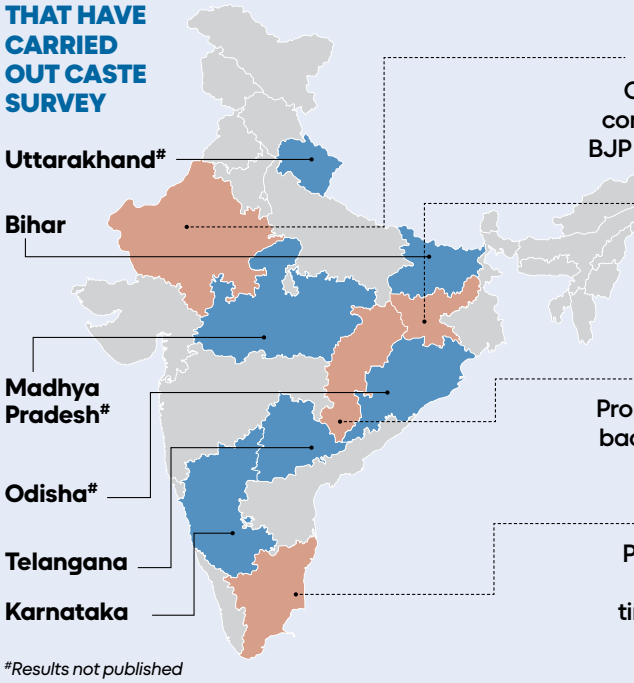
A NEW SOCIAL ORDER

A few states have already undertaken their version of a caste survey, some others are readying for it. Only 2-3 have published the results which, as expected, have unleashed mini storms



STATES PLANNING IT

Rajasthan Previous Congress regime had conceived it; post-2023, BJP regime put it on hold

Jharkhand Survey announced in 2023; delayed due to legal/ political hurdles

Chhattisgarh Proposal made; political backing in principle, but nothing official yet

Tamil Nadu Pushing for a national caste census, biding time on its own survey

4,147
Total no. of castes in 1931 Census

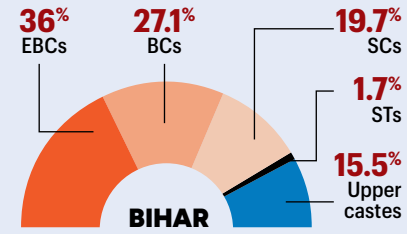
4.6 MILLION
No. of 'unique caste names' in 2011 SECC*

2,479
No. of OBC groups as per Central list

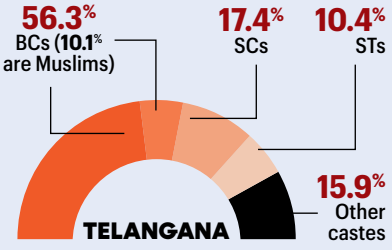
3,150
No. of OBC groups as per state/UT lists

** Socio-Economic Caste Census*

SURVEY RESULTS



Of the 203 notified castes, 112 are EBC, 30 OBC, 22 SC and 32 ST. Four Hindu (Rajput, Kayastha, Brahmin, Bhumihar) and three Muslim (Sheikh, Pathan, Syed) castes in general category



Backward Classes form the majority of Telangana's population—56% of the 35.4 million people covered by the survey

sation as socio-economic, not religious. The new BJP strategy includes Pasmanda Muslims, said to be sidelined by the Ashraf elite. "For years, Muslims were treated as a vote bank, ignoring internal disparities," says senior BJP leader and Union minister Bhupender Yadav. "Pasmanda Muslims and the women suffered because of this. Transparent data will help address these gaps."

STATES AND CASTES

Nowhere is the issue of caste census more politically charged than in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. The Bihar's grand alliance government conducted a caste survey in 2023, revealing that OBCs and EBCs (Extremely Backward Classes) made up 63 per cent of the population, and with SCs and STs, the total reached 84 per cent. The findings confirmed what backward caste leaders had long claimed—numerical dominance but poor representation in jobs and education. In response, the state moved to raise reservations to 65 per cent, breaching the Supreme Court-set 50 per cent cap. The Patna High Court struck it down in 2024; the matter is now before the apex court. Interestingly, the BJP had supported the caste census resolution in Bihar in 2022, aware of the political cost of opposing it in a state where the OBC identity is central. With Bihar due for an election later this year, the Centre's nod to a caste census is seen as the BJP's attempt to reclaim ground from regional parties that have long owned the OBC narrative.

As for UP, considered a BJP stronghold, the ground turned shaky in the Lok Sabha election last year. The Hindutva-backed caste coalition (non-Yadav OBCs, upper castes and some non-Jatav Dalits) which helped it sweep the 2014 and 2019 elections showed signs of a crack. Akhilesh Yadav's Samajwadi Party and the Congress capitalised on it with a PDA pitch—uniting Pichhda (Backward Classes), Dalits and Alpasankhyak (minorities)